

Global Horror: The True Face of the System

In *Zero Sum*, the most terrifying monsters are human logistics, unchecked algorithms, and the global supply chain. The horror is grounded entirely in the real world of 2026. Blood is the lubricant of the modern digital age.

1. The Cyber-Cartels (Latin America)

The cartels of the 2020s are no longer just drug runners; they are heavily armed tech conglomerates. * **The Horror:** They don't just kidnap people for ransom; they kidnap telecommunications engineers to build private, shadow cellular networks across the jungle. They use militarized drones to drop explosives and employ ex-special forces with night-vision optics. * **The Thriller Aspect:** A cartel doesn't just shoot a journalist. They use NSO-style spyware to track the journalist's family, send them a livestream of their living room, and force the journalist to write cartel propaganda to save their children.

2. The Panopticon & Social Erasure (East Asia)

In highly authoritarian states, violence is rarely necessary because the system can simply delete your existence. * **The Horror:** Complete biometric and algorithmic surveillance. Cameras with gait-recognition track you even if you wear a mask. If you are labeled a dissident, your digital currency wallets are zeroed out, your apartment's smart-locks refuse to open, and anyone whose phone comes within 10 feet of yours receives an automatic deduction to their own social credit score. * **The Thriller Aspect:** The players aren't running from bullets; they are running from an invisible algorithmic contagion. To help a dissident is to become a pariah. They must navigate a mega-city without ever showing their face to a lens or using an electronic device.

3. The Blood-Mines and PMC Warlords (Central Africa)

The batteries for every electric vehicle and burner phone in the game come from the Democratic Republic of Congo and similar regions. * **The Horror:** Massive, open-pit mines guarded by heavily armed Private Military Companies (PMCs) hired by Western and Eastern mega-corporations. The actual mining is done by thousands of desperate locals, including children, digging cobalt by hand in toxic mud. * **The Thriller Aspect:** Players investigating a “clean tech” billionaire’s supply chain must travel to a heavily fortified PMC black-zone. Here, human life has a literal, mathematically calculated dollar value, and the PMCs have shoot-to-kill authorization with zero international oversight.

4. The Spyware Hubs & Digital Assassins (Middle East)

The birthplace of the world’s most terrifying cyber-weapons. * **The Horror:** Intelligence veterans transitioning into the private sector to sell zero-click exploits to dictatorships. These tools are used to track human rights activists, leading to their real-world torture and dismemberment. * **The Thriller Aspect:** The players discover their devices have been infected. They aren’t just being tracked; their microphones are being used to record their allies. The horror of knowing that a silent string of code, sold legally from an office building in Tel Aviv or Dubai, is going to result in a hit-team kicking down their door at 3 AM.

5. Extraordinary Rendition & The Black Sites (Eastern Europe)

The bureaucratic, sterilized horror of the “Global War on Terror” infrastructure, now repurposed for corporate and political enemies. * **The Horror:** You don’t get a trial. You get a hood placed over your head in an airport parking lot, loaded onto an unmarked Gulfstream jet, and flown to a secret prison operating in a legal gray zone (like historical sites in Poland or Romania). * **The Thriller Aspect:** “Enhanced interrogation.” Sleep deprivation, sound torture, and sensory deprivation. If a player or their Tie is taken, the rescue mission isn’t just a shootout; it’s a desperate race to find a building that doesn’t officially exist before the victim’s mind is permanently broken.

6. Militarized AI and Autonomous Warfare (The Drone-Zones)

In the active warzones and resource-extraction borders of 2026, humans have been removed from the kill chain. * **The Horror:** Entire territories are designated as “Autonomous Containment Zones” (ACZs), policed by low-altitude drone swarms executing algorithmic targeting models. These systems do not require human authorization to fire; they scan for biometric gait signatures, thermal profiles, and electronic emissions. If an individual matches the behavioral model of a combatant or a trespasser (e.g., running, carrying a metallic object, hiding under foliage), the algorithm registers them as a target and dispatches a kinetic micro-drone to execute them. * **The Thriller Aspect:** Players navigating a drone-zone cannot use their kinetics to dodge bullets or hide from guards. They are fighting mathematical probabilities. They must keep their heart rates low, mask their heat signatures, and move in irregular, non-human patterns to avoid triggering the automated classification algorithm. A single panicky sprint can flag them as “threat signature: positive” and trigger a swarm.

7. Digital Asylums (Algorithmic Gaslighting)

When the system cannot capture your body, it captures your past, trapping you in a jail built of artificial memories. * **The Horror:** The Factions use coordinated, deepfake-driven campaigns to isolate and mentally break high-value targets. By hacking a target’s personal archives, smart-home devices, and digital history, they systematically alter their reality. Old emails are subtly modified, family photographs are replaced with generated versions containing strangers, and voice messages from loved ones are synthetic fabrications denying shared experiences. The target is isolated from friends who are fed deepfaked videos of the target committing crimes or suffering psychotic breaks, forcing them into a state of absolute self-doubt. * **The Thriller Aspect:** The players are not just fighting the surveillance state; they are fighting their own minds. When their own digital backups show their dead contact was a double agent, or that a mission they remember never occurred, they must roll Detachment to avoid a severe mental break. They must rely on low-tech analog journals, physical photographs, and offline trust to anchor their reality before the digital asylum drives them to madness.